

The Lost MUSIC

This novel of big ideas and little stories is poised between East and West

By Shuddhabrata Sengupta



SOLO
by RANA DASGUPTA
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A blind, nearly 100-year-old man named Ulrich sits alone in a ramshackle, leaking apartment in Sofia, the capital of Bulgaria, listening to the television that he cannot see, dreaming music, chemistry and the detritus of the 20th century.

Outside, there is a bus station, the bustle, stench and commerce of people from all over the Balkans, money changers and vagabonds, the things they buy and sell that come all the way from China, and the lingering stench of a wall that doubles up as an open-air urinal. Two times cohabit within the walls of Ulrich's inner life. The intoxicant sensory overload of the present and the distilled recall of the past make for uncanny neighbours. The exchange between them, which stretches from the last days of Ottoman empire in Bulgaria and early 20th-century Berlin to an invocation of the surreal excess and impoverishment of the contemporary world, taking in Tbilisi, New York, Los Angeles and even the shadow of Baghdad in its embrace, underpins the narrative of Rana Dasgupta's wonderful new book.

Solo is poised between East and West, between music and chemistry, between love and loneliness, between solitude and anonymity, between tenderness and violence, between the still receding past and the still unfolding future, between memories and daydreams. The memories, incandescent crystals of rare chemical elements, speak with candour of the grit, grandiosity and the failure of the 20th century. They are answered by daydreams, which rise like submarine creatures from the frozen depths of imminence into the thin daylight of now to beach themselves on the shore of a strangely compassionate, yet lucid absence of either redemption or despair. The unruly, beautiful, sometimes violent, always vivid and alive dreams



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are the progeny, in more ways than is obvious, of the old man's relentless remembering. They are the children he had and lost, the tunes he played and abandoned, the ideals that imprisoned and liberated him, the things he was yet somehow could not be. They are the wake of the 20th century and the precarious foreshadowing of the yet to be comprehended enormity of the 21st. They are a call to account for all our failures and an invocation to persist with all our desires.

It is customary, when considering a novel that embraces music as significantly as *Solo* does, to think about how it treats the sonic